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February 6, 2026

Distinguished Teaching Award Committee

Dear Committee Members,

It is my pleasure to write this departmental letter of support for **Nallely Valenzuela** in her nomination for a Distinguished Teaching Award. While I am Nallely's dissertation chair, I have not personally supervised Nallely as a teaching assistant in my own courses. I know her work well through her broader teaching record through my role as Vice Chair.

In that capacity, I selected Nallely to serve as the instructor for Political Science 495A and 495B, the core pedagogy and professionalization courses in which we train our incoming graduate students to become effective teaching assistants. This is a role we reserve for instructors who demonstrate not only excellence in the classroom, but also exceptional judgment, professionalism, and an ability to model best practices in teaching. Nallely excelled on all of these dimensions. She approached the courses with seriousness of purpose, intellectual creativity, and a deep commitment to supporting graduate students as developing educators.

Student feedback from 495A speaks clearly to the success of her approach. Graduate students consistently describe her as thoughtful in course design, explicit in expectations, and deeply invested in their learning and professional growth. One student noted that she "created an open and inviting environment for discussion and collaboration" and that the course expectations were clear, the readings carefully chosen, and the overall structure supportive.

What stands out across evaluations is Nallely's ability to foster meaningful discussion—often cited as the highlight of her courses. Students repeatedly remarked that discussions in her fully online courses were deeper and more engaging than many of their in-person classes. This is a remarkable achievement and speaks to her skill in facilitating inclusive, intellectually rigorous conversations. As one student observed, although they entered the course with limited interest in the topic, the discussions and lectures ultimately made it one of their most enjoyable academic experiences.

Students also praise her clarity in breaking down complex readings, her use of active-learning strategies (including debates, group work, games, and structured discussions), and her responsiveness outside of class. Many highlight her flexibility and generosity with office hours, her detailed and constructive feedback on papers, and her empathy during periods of political tension and disruption on campus. Across these evaluations, students repeatedly emphasize that her sections felt welcoming, well-organized, intellectually stimulating, and supportive of student success.

Equally important, students describe Nallely as someone who makes the classroom a safe and affirming space for learning—particularly for students who are developing confidence in speaking and academic argumentation. Her positive demeanor, approachability, and visible love of learning create an environment in which students feel encouraged to take intellectual risks and engage deeply with material that often requires significant critical reflection.

Taken together, these evaluations reflect an instructor who combines pedagogical innovation, intellectual rigor, and genuine care for her students.

Sincerely,



Margaret Peters
Professor and Vice Chair of Graduate Studies
Political Science
UCLA

DTA Nominee Statement

My name is Nallely Valenzuela and I am a Ph.D. candidate in the department of Political Science. I have had the opportunity to serve as a Teaching Assistant for a wide variety of courses including: World Politics, Peace and War, International Relations Theory, Governance and Conflict, and 20th Century Political Theory. During my years at UCLA, I have found my role as a Teaching Assistant to be the most rewarding dimension of my academic career.

As a first-generation Latina scholar, I have experienced how transformative it is when educators have a meaningful impact on their students. These educators positively changed the trajectory of my own education, and form a large part as to my position in graduate school today. My overarching goals as a TA are to cultivate an inclusive classroom environment that fosters a sense of belonging, promotes student-lead discussions, and challenges students academically. My student evaluations directly reflect these goals. In my end of the quarter evaluations, one student from my Governance and Conflict discussion wrote: "TA Nallely is one of the best TA's I have had while being at UCLA. She is intelligent and approachable. She understands students needs and is ready to answer questions or help students. Truly it was a pleasure being able to be a student under her discussion section." Additionally, a student from my International Relations Theory discussion wrote: "I enjoyed the way Nallely approaches discussions on the readings for class. They were very helpful for helping me understand the content but were very student-led, rightfully preventing discussion from becoming a lecture." Across the board I have maintained an average overall rating as a TA at an 8.5/10.

Due to my positive evaluations, my department has granted me the opportunity to not only make a positive impact on student learning for undergraduates but also graduate students. This academic year, I am serving as the Teaching Assistant Consultant (TAC) for my department, a competitive position awarded in recognition of demonstrated excellence in teaching and mentorship. In this role, I teach the 495 sequence for incoming Teaching Assistants. I support and mentor incoming TAs as they develop their own pedological approaches. I lead instruction on effective discussion facilitation, including inclusive teaching

practices, and strategies for engaging in diverse classrooms. Serving as a TAC allows me to extend my teaching philosophy beyond my own sections and contribute to the professional development of graduate students in my department.

Based on my demonstrating passion for teaching and effectiveness in the classroom, my department entrusted me with teaching an original course during two summer sessions. This role required full responsibility for course design, instruction, and assessment and reflected confidence in my ability to independently lead a class. Teaching my own course allowed me to intentionally implement student-centered and inclusive teaching practices, while supporting students throughout the learning process.

Expanding my knowledge on teaching and learning is very important to me. I actively seek out additional coursework focused on pedagogy beyond my required training in the 495 departmental sequence, which I took throughout my first and second years as a graduate student. I have completed 3 English Composition courses in the Graduate Writing Pedagogy Program which allow me to strengthen my teaching practice by learning evidence-based approaches, inclusive pedagogy, and student-centered learning. These courses are made up of graduate students from interdisciplinary backgrounds, which teaches me how different disciplines approach learning and teaching. This exposure allows me to expanding my pedagogical toolkit and enables me to create more effective learning experiences for all students.

DTA Teaching Philosophy

My teaching philosophy emphasizes active, student-centered learning that challenges students to apply theory to real-world contexts. As illustrated in Teaching Artifact #1, I regularly ask students to work in small groups to analyze contemporary cases, such as applying concepts like incomplete information, commitment problems, and issue indivisibility to the Russia–Ukraine war. This artifact, an excerpt from my slide on rationalist explanations for war, demonstrates how I encourage collaborative learning, support inclusive participation, and help students build confidence in engaging with complex material. By guiding students from small-group discussions to whole-class synthesis, I create opportunities for them to refine their ideas, learn from diverse perspectives, and connect abstract concepts to pressing global issues.

In my teaching, I also prioritize clarity and transparency to ensure that all students understand the expectations for the course and for participation, effectively demystifying the "hidden curriculum" that often disadvantages students unfamiliar with academic norms. Teaching Artifact #2 demonstrates how I explicitly walk students through grading rubrics and evaluation criteria. By making course expectations and evaluation criteria explicit, I work to remove barriers that can disadvantage students and provide tools for all learners to participate and excel. This approach is particularly meaningful to me as a first-generation college student, as I experienced firsthand how ambiguous expectations can create unnecessary barriers to academic success. By making these norms explicit, I help students navigate the course with confidence and agency, supporting their growth as independent thinkers. Teaching Artifact #3 also adds transparency as I explicitly mention how students will be evaluated in discussion sections. By being clear about how they will be graded, I allow them to succeed on their own terms, rather than leaving them to navigate hidden rules, so they can focus on learning and developing their skills.

Part of my teaching philosophy is to connect abstract concepts to contexts that students already understand, making complex ideas more approachable and relevant. Using

examples from outside the discipline helps students see the real-world applications of theory and encourages them to think creatively about how concepts operate in different settings. For instance, as Teaching Artifact #4 demonstrates, I have used football to introduce game theory, framing strategic interactions through a "game of chicken" scenario in which neither player wants to yield first, illustrating how decisions depend on anticipating others' choices. Anchoring abstract ideas in familiar experiences helps students engage more fully, build confidence in their analytical skills, and see that theory is not bounded to the classroom.

Rationalist Explanations for War

Before I break them into groups we first discuss the concepts to make sure that then we can apply them to real world issues - here we cover the main characteristics of incomplete information

1) Incomplete Information

- Actors do not know all information about other actors' abilities and interests
  - Capabilities
  - Resolve

- How can actors increase their credibility?
  - Brinksmanship
  - Tying hands
  - Sinking costs
- What is a disadvantage of increasing credibility?

Rationalist Explanations for War

We discuss the main characteristics of commitment problems

- **2) Commitment Problems**
  - Difficult for actors to make promises of not using force in the future when they have an opportunity to do so

- Sources of credible commitment problems
  - Bargaining over future power
  - Preventing shifting power
    - Preventive war
  - Preempting fear of imminent attack
    - Preemptive war

Rationalist Explanations for War

We discuss the main characteristics of issue indivisibility

3) Issue indivisibility

- Most of the things that states fight or bargain over are not easily divisible

- Ultimately must fight to get all or nothing… However, what does Fearon (1995) argue can combat this?
  - Issue linkages

Group Activity

Students discuss as a group, give them around 10 minutes, then we discuss as a class. This enhances collaboration among students, especially helpful for students who are shy to participate but once discussing with their peers, gain the confidence to share out loud. Also students learn new perspectives that they would have otherwise not considered if they did not have the opportunity conversate.

- Form groups of 4-5 and answer these questions:
  - How does incomplete information apply to the Russo-Ukrainian War?
  - How do commitment problems apply to the Russo-Ukrainian War?
  - How does issue indivisibility apply to the Russo-Ukrainian War?

GLBL ST 103: Governance and Conflict / Group White Paper Grading Rubric

Category	Exceeds Standards	Meets Standards	Does Not Meet Standards	Ignores Standards
Executive summary (10%)	• One page • Effectively reviews key points of the white paper (9-10)	• One page • Reviews key points of the white paper (7-8)	• Exceeds one page • Partially reviews key points of the white paper (5-6)	• Absent (0-4)
Background (15%)	• Provides a useful background for the issue • Background is concise and establishes only relevant information (14-15)	• Provides a fairly useful background for the issue • Background is somewhat concise but also presents some excess information (10-13)	• Provides an incomplete or background for the issue • Background is longer than necessary and presents excess information (6-9)	• Provides no background for the issue • Background is much longer than necessary and is filled with irrelevant information (0-5)
Policy options (20%)	• Presents three or four policy options that are reasonable and distinct • Pros and cons of each option are effectively addressed (18-20)	• Presents three or four policy options that are reasonable and distinct • Pros and cons of each option are generally addressed (14-17)	• Does not present three or four options that are reasonable and distinct • Pros and cons of each option are incompletely addressed (10-13)	• Does not present three or four options that are reasonable and distinct • Pros and cons of each option are inadequately addressed (0-9)
Policy stance (10%)	• Paper makes a clear proposal in favor of one policy option • Paper effectively argues why this option is best (9-10)	• Paper makes a clear proposal in favor of one policy option • Paper argues why this option is best (7-8)	• Paper makes a clear proposal in favor of one policy option • Paper does not clearly argue why this option is best (5-6)	• Paper does not make a clear proposal in favor of one policy option (0-4)
Data analysis (10%)	• Paper includes analysis of reputable quantitative data • Analysis is highly effective in supporting a claim. (9-10)	• Paper includes analysis of reputable quantitative data • Analysis is somewhat relevant to supporting a claim. (7-8)	• Paper includes analysis of reputable quantitative data • Analysis is irrelevant to supporting a claim. (5-6)	• Paper does not include any analysis of reputable quantitative data (0-4)
Organization (10%)	• Effective use of titles, headers, visuals • Individual points are presented in a very logical fashion • Paper is well-organized overall and reads like a coherent work (9-10)	• Titles, headers, and visuals are present • Individual points are presented in a generally logical fashion • Paper is generally organized overall, but some parts feel out of place or "pasted" together (7-8)	• Titles, headers, and visuals are sometimes absent • Individual points are presented in a rather unclear fashion • Paper is not well organized overall, and parts feel out of place or "pasted" together (5-6)	• Titles, headers, and visuals are basically absent • Individual points are presented in an unclear fashion • Paper is poorly organized and feels inconsistent or sloppily "pasted" together (0-4)
Sources (10%)	• 12 or more reputable sources • 4 or more from class readings • 3 or more outside scholarly sources (9-10)	• Paper satisfies two of the three criteria in the "Exceeds Standards" column. (7-8)	• Paper satisfies one of the three criteria in the "Exceeds Standards" column. (5-6)	• Paper satisfies none of the three criteria in the "Exceeds Standards" column. (0-4)
Language (10%)	• Largely free of typos and errors • Professional tone (9-10)	• Some typos and errors, which become somewhat distracting • Mostly professional tone (7-8)	• Frequent typos and errors, which become distracting • Slightly unprofessional tone (5-6)	• Many typos and errors, which become very distracting • Unprofessional tone (0-4)
AI disclosure and contributions statements (5%)	• AI disclosure statement is included and offers useful and transparent information on use of AI. • Contribution statement is included and offers clear information on each group member's contribution to the paper. (5)		• AI disclosure and contribution statements technically included but offer limited information, or only one statement of the two included. (1-4)	• AI disclosure and contribution statements completely missing. (0)

Together, as a class, we go over how students will be assessed. Students volunteer to read one category of the rubric. We then point out differences between exceeds standards, meets standards, etc. This makes it very explicit what differentiates an A from a B paper. By doing so I give students feedback on the type of work they must produce to succeed in this course.

Group White Paper

- Prompt: How should the United States manage the international consequences of its intervention in Venezuela, particularly with respect to global governance, international cooperation, and future state behavior?
- 3-4 potential policy approaches, choose 1 that the US should pursue
- 15-20 pages (depending on group members)
- Quantitative Data (Week 3 or 4)

Once we go over the rubric, I then break down the requirements into digestible information, and explicitly mention the important aspects of the assignment. This reliefs student stress and also gives them confidence to navigate this task with ease.

Global Studies 103: Governance and Conflict

Nallely Valenzuela

Section Syllabus - Winter 2026

Email: nallelyvalen@g.ucla.edu
Office Hours: Monday 1:00pm - 2:40pm or by appointment (ZOOM)
Sections: F 10-10:50am *Bunche* 3143, 11-11:50pm *Bunche* 3153, 12-12:50pm *Haines* A20

Section Description

Sections are a way for students to attain a clear understanding of the course readings. You should come to section with an open-mind, and having read the material. Please note that sections are **not** designed to regurgitate the material from class lectures. Rather, discussion is designed to help build connections with lecture material and assigned readings. Some discussion sections will also be dedicated to working on the group white paper.

Grade Breakdown

I explicitly mention how students will be evaluated and provide transparency allowing them to succeed in this course at their own terms.

Section attendance and participation account for 20% of your final grade.

- Attendance 10%:

Attendance is mandatory. You should arrive to section on time and prepared to discuss readings and concepts from lecture. You are allowed **one** excused absence during the quarter with no questions asked and no documentation required. Any additional absences will require documentation to be considered excused.

- Participation 10%:

Speaking during sections is expected. Expressing your opinions during class can be challenging however your thoughts and questions are valued and essential to class discussions. As always please be respectful of your peers' opinions.

Office Hours

My intention is for every one of you to excel in this course, please feel free to seek assistance about anything related to the course. My office hours will take place Mondays from 1:00pm - 2:40pm on ZOOM. Please sign up using this link: https://calendly.com/nallelyvalen-1. After you sign up an email will be sent with the ZOOM link. If these times do not work for you I am happy to schedule an appointment at another time through email.

Email Policy

Please compose emails with proper salutations. Allow at least two business days to receive a response from me. If you do not receive a response, feel free to send a follow up email.

Important Dates

- February 6 - Executive Summary Draft Due
- March 9 - Group White Paper Due
- March 13 - Peer Participation Assessment Due

Academic Dishonesty

Academic dishonesty is taken very seriously at UCLA, and violators will be sent through a judicial process. Cheating and plagiarism will **not** be tolerated under any circumstance.

Self-care and Student Resources

Life can be difficult at times. It is important to prioritize yourself in order to ensure long-term success. Although your academic life is important, it is equally as important to take time off and do things that bring you happiness and peace. If you are experiencing a troubling moment that is obstructing your performance please talk to me. If you prefer to speak with a professional consider contacting UCLA CAPS: https://counseling.ucla.edu.

Additional Student Resources:

- Arthur Ashe Student Health and Wellness Center: https://www.studenthealth.ucla.edu
- Bruin Resource Center: http://www.brc.ucla.edu/
- Lesbian Gay Bisexual Transgender Campus Resource Center: http://www.lgbt.ucla.edu/
- Dashew Center for International Students: http://www.internationalcenter.ucla.edu/
- Community Programs Office: http://uclacommunityprograms.org/
- Office for Students with Disabilities: http://www.osd.ucla.edu/
- Bruin Shelter: https://basicneeds.ucla.edu/bruin-shelter

GAME THEORY

Chicken



Visual representation of the two football players in this game theory example



Player 1

Player 2

	C	D
C	Both swerve, no one is harmed or humiliated	Aaron continues running and Tom swerves, Aaron wins and Tom is the "chicken"
D	Tom continues running and Aaron swerves, Tom wins and Aaron is the "chicken"	Both continue running, Tom and Aaron are killed from a head injury

Start off with the game of chicken in words as to what actions these two players will take

Once students understand the actions, we then incorporate the numbers associated with the actions and find the game equilibrium

Chicken



Player 2

4 – best outcome
3 – second best outcome
2 – third best outcome
1 – worst outcome

*** Equilibrium**



Player 1

	C	D
C	Both swerve, no one is harmed or humiliated 3,3	Aaron continues running and Tom swerves, Aaron wins and Tom is the "chicken" 2,4*
D	Tom continues running and Aaron swerves, Tom wins and Aaron is the "chicken" 4, 2*	Both continue running, Tom and Aaron are killed from a head injury 1,1

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

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Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

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Political Science

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Los Angeles, CA 90095
https://ericmin.com
(913) 485-7347

To Whom It May Concern:

My name is Eric Min, and I am an associate professor in the Department of Political Science and International Institute. I am extremely pleased to recommend Nallely Valenzuela for the Distinguished Teaching Award.

Nallely has served a teaching assistant (TA) for me in five past courses and one current course. The first instance was in Fall 2021, where she was a TA for POL SCI 20 ("World Politics"), which is an introductory course on international relations. The course is often the students' first in their university careers; the best TAs here are not only addressing class materials, but also offering valuable guidance and professionalization that will shape their success at UCLA and future endeavors. Nallely clearly met this high bar. My personal observations and her teaching evaluations all demonstrated Nallely's blend of knowledge, approachability, kindness, humor, and dedication to nurturing valuable life skills.

It was because Nallely was so effective that I asked her to be a TA in my upper-division course, GLBL ST 103 ("Governance and Conflict") in Spring 2022. Nallely helped guide 75 students through very dense material—including academic journal articles—on issues of international conflict and global politics. A key assignment in the course is a group paper where random clusters of five students spent the quarter writing an extended paper addressing the Russian invasion of Ukraine. This is a difficult assignment, but Nallely remained equally effective in helping students navigate more complex materials and varied intra-group dynamics.

It is thus no surprise that I have repeatedly sought out Nallely. She was thus an RA for POL SCI 20 again in Fall 2022, and she has been part of GLBL ST 103 in the Winter 2024 and current Winter 2026 quarters. Each term, students who come to my office hours are effusive about Nallely. Some students have mentioned their deep appreciation for Nallely's ability and willingness to demystify academia. As a first-generation scholar herself, Nallely is passionate about opening doors for others who are also the first in their families to attend college. In that sense, Nallely's impact goes far beyond any single course she has taught.

Our department has also recognized Nallely's obvious strengths as an instructor, making her the Teaching Assistant Consultant who is responsible for teaching POL SCI 495—our sequence to train graduate teaching assistants. She also taught two summer courses, being chosen from a competitive field of graduate students. While I believe some of her teaching skills are innate, Nallely also goes out of her way to further hone her pedagogical abilities. Her participation in the Graduate Certificate in Writing Pedagogy program, which offers training to guide undergraduate writing, is one example of her efforts at continuous self-improvement.

As such, I recommend Nallely in very high terms for this award. She is the most dependable TA I have had in my time at UCLA. I am happy to answer additional questions about Nallely. Please do not hesitate to contact me by e-mail at eric.min@ucla.edu or by phone at (913) 485-7347.

Sincerely,



Eric Min